

General Knowledge

Ancient History

STUDY NOTES

Harshavardhan



The Reign of Harshavardhana



Introduction to Harshavardhan's Rule

Early Life and Ascension to the Throne

- Harshavardhan, also known as Harsha, was born in 590 CE in Thanesar, located in present-day Haryana.
- He belonged to the Pushyabhuti dynasty, also called the Vardhana dynasty, which ruled over a small kingdom in northern India.
- Harsha's father, Prabhakarvardhan, was the ruler of Thanesar, and his elder brother, Rajyavardhan, was the crown prince.
- After the tragic death of Rajyavardhan and the assassination of Harsha's sister's husband, Grahavarman, Harsha ascended the throne of Thanesar at the young age of 16.
- Initially, his rule was confined to the small kingdom of Thanesar, but he had ambitions of uniting northern India.
- Harsha was a Hindu Brahmin who was a **follower of Shiva till 631 AD.**
- Later he came under the **influence of sister Rajyashri and Buddhist monk Hieun Tsang.**

- He embraced the Mahayana school of thought of Buddhism and converted himself to Buddhism.
- He was a **secular ruler** and respected all religions and faiths.
- He was a great scholar and a noted author. He wrote 3 Sanskrit plays namely **Ratnavali**, **Priyadarshika**, and **Nagananda**.

Ratnavali (Precious Garland):

- It is a **Sanskrit drama** about a beautiful princess named **Ratnavali**, and a King named **Udayana**.
- The drama is divided into four acts.
- Some **textual references** like a **celebration of Holi** and the festival of Colors have been found.
- He was a **great patron of art and literature** which attracted many artists. Eg. **Banabhatta**

Harshavardhana's political expansion:

Expansion:

- His first campaign was against the **Shashanka of Gauda** to take revenge for killing his elder brother **Rajya Vardhana** and kidnapping his sister **Rajyashri**. For this, he forged an **alliance** with **Bhaskaravarman**, the **Kamarupa king**, and waged a war. Ultimately, **Shashanka** was defeated.
- **Harsha later claimed the sovereign rulership of Kannauj also.**
- Harsha **united the two kingdoms of Thanesar and Kannauj** and made his capital **Kannauj**.
- Harsha was able to unite many independent kingdoms under his command. Eg.
 - He was under the control of **Punjab and central India**.
 - He annexed **Bengal, Bihar, and Odisha**.
 - He also defeated the **Vallabhi king in Gujarat**.
- However, Harsha failed to conquer lands to the south **when the Chalukya king, Pulakeshin- II defeated Harsha in 618-619 A.D.**
- This **restricted Harsha's southern territorial extent up to the Narmada River**.

Contemporary Kingdoms:

These kingdoms were the **feudatories** of one or the other kingdoms. **They revolted and claimed the rulership.** The impact of feudalism became more visible from the time of the Harsha period.

- Chalukya kingdom with capital Vatapi.
- Pallavas kingdom with capital Kanchipuram.
- Kalinga kingdom
- Chera kingdom
- Chola kingdom with capital Thanjavur.
- Pandya kingdom with capital Madurai.



Political Structure and Administration:

Polity:

- There were two types of territories under Harsha's rule:
 - **Direct controlling: Bengal, Kalinga, Central Provinces, Rajputana, and Gujarat.**
 - **Feudatories: Jalandhar, Kashmir, Kamarupa, Sind, and Nepal.**

Decentralized political structure:

Aspect	Details
Central Authority	Harshavardhan maintained strong central authority as the supreme ruler. Key decisions, including military and administrative, were centralized.
Provincial Administration	The empire was divided into provinces (often referred to as Bhuktis), each governed by a Governor (appointed by the central authority).
District Administration	Provinces were subdivided into districts (Vishayas), managed by district officers (Vishayapatis) responsible for local governance.
Village Administration	Villages formed the smallest administrative units, governed by village headmen (Gramika), who handled day-to-day village matters.
Role of Local Assemblies	Some local administrative councils or assemblies existed in villages and towns, though with limited powers under the overall control of governors.

Revenue Collection	Taxes were collected by regional officials, but certain land grants provided local landholders with the right to collect taxes from their lands.
Land Grants (Feudalism)	Large land grants (Agraharas) were given to religious figures (Brahmins, Buddhists), leading to decentralization of revenue collection and control.
Judicial Decentralization	Governors and district officers had judicial responsibilities, but landholders who received grants could also settle local disputes.

Feudalism

- The impacts of feudalism became more visible during the Harshavardha's rule.
- Feudalism means the landed nobility held lands from the king in exchange for military service. The land was granted in villages, which made the local landlords powerful.
- During this period, having land rights was considered a socially superior position in society.
- Among the society, Brahmins were the major landlords who positioned themselves stronger. They also got a lot of concessions from the king, especially with the exemptions from paying taxes.
- Other feudal lords apart from the Brahmins, started influencing their control over their territories and started revolting against the King of the empire. Eg. Defying orders from the top, non-payment of taxes, etc.
- This led to the breakup of the empire into many feudatory independent states.

Economy:

- He had a good tax structure in the administration.
- **Harsha imposed primarily 3 kinds of taxes namely, Bhaga, Hiranya, and Bali.**
- **Bhaga was the land tax. One-sixth of the produce** was collected as land revenue.
- **Hiranya was the tax paid in cash by farmers and merchants.**
- **Bali was an additional oppressive tax. Eg. Penalty for non-payment of other taxes on time by the people.**

- **The revenue account was divided into four parts.**
 - **Part I** - for carrying out the affairs of the state.
 - **Part II** - for paying the ministers and officers of the crown.
 - **Part III**- for rewarding men of letters.
 - **Part IV** - for charity to religious institutions.
- **25 % of all the taxes collected were used for charity and cultural purposes.**

Military:

- Harsha became a **capable conqueror and administrator.**
- During his rule, Harshavardhana **constructed a robust army.**
- **Historical statistics propose that he had 100,000 robust cavalries, 50,000 infantry, and 60,000 elephants all through the height of his reign.**

Administration:

- It appears that the **ministerial administration during the reign of Harsha was more feudalized and decentralized.**
- **The feudal practice of rewarding and paying officers with grants of land seems to have begun under Harsha. This explains why we don't have too many coins issued by Harsha.**
- The emperor was **assisted by a Mantri Parishads i.e. Council of Ministers** in his duties.
- The **council played an important role** in the **selection of the king as well as in framing the policies.** Eg. Foreign policy of the empire.
- **The prime minister was the most important position** in the council of ministers.
- Key Officials:
 - **Avanti** - Minister for Foreign Relations and War
 - **Simhanada** - Commander-in-Chief
 - **Kuntala** - Chief Cavalry Officer
 - **Skandagupta** - Chief Commandant of Elephant Force
 - **Dirghadhvaj**as - Royal Messengers
 - **Banu** - Keeper of Records
 - **Mahaprathihara** - Chief of the Palace Guard 8. Sarvagata - Secret Service Department.

Justice system:

- **Criminal law was very strict compared to** that of the Gupta age.
- **Mimamsakas were appointed as Judges to deliver justice.**
- Banishment and the cutting of limbs of the body were the common punishments.

- Trial by ordeal was in practice.
- **Life imprisonment for the violations of the laws and for plotting against the king.**
- **Law and order were not maintained well in the society, according to Hieun Tsang's records. Eg. Hieun Tsang was robbed once.**
- The **pilgrim records the principal penalties and judicial ordeals** practised in India at that time.
- Corporal punishment for serious offences was in practice. However, the **death penalty was usually avoided. Death punishment existed earlier but after Harsha accepted Buddhism, it was changed to life imprisonment.**
- **Offences against social morality and defiance of the law were punished by maiming.**

Cultural contributions:

Literature:

Heiun Tsang's Si-Yu-Ki literature (630–643 AD):

- Chinese pilgrims spent nearly 13 years in India (630–643 AD).
- He collected **sacred texts and relics** which he took back to China.
- **He was known as the “prince of pilgrims”** because he visited important pilgrim centres associated with the life of Buddha.
- He provides **detailed information about the social, economic, religious, and cultural conditions during the reign of Harsha.**
- Some of his **observations** were as follows:
 - Buddhism was popular only in East India.
 - Nalanda was the notable leading educational university at that time.
 - Prayag and Kanauj became important centers where Patliputra and Vaishali were on the decline.
 - Brahmanas and Kshatriyas lived a simple life.
 - Nobles and priests lived a luxurious life.
 - He called Shudras an agriculturist which was significant.
 - There was the existence of a caste system.
 - Bad treatment was given to untouchables. They used to live outside the village. The announcements were made before their arrival.
 - People were encouraged to give up meat.

- Dressing patterns varied regionally.
- Indians were short-tempered but hygienic and honest.
- No criminals existed because of strict laws and punishments.
- Life imprisonment was the highest punishment. There was no death sentence.

I-Tsing(671-695 AD):

- He was not contemporary to Harshavardhana but his writings throw light on the important aspects of life during Harsha's rule.
- **He was a Chinese traveller.**
- He visited India in connection with Buddhism.
- **He studied for 5 years regarding rules of discipline i.e. Vinaya Pitaka which remained his main interest. It was his main theme of writing.**
- He was aware of Fa-Hien and Hieun Tsang's literary sources.
- His works **are biographies of eminent monks of Nalanda University.**
- **He gave useful information about the social, religious, and cultural life of the people of India.**

Banabhatta (606-647 AD):

- He was a poet in Harsha's court.
- Bana's principal works include a biography of Harsha named **the Harshacharita** (Deeds of Harsha), and **Kadambari**: one of the world's earliest novels.
- **Harshacharita gives an account of Harsha's life and deeds in the form of verses.**

Social Significance:

Caste System:

- The **caste system was firmly established** in Hindu society.
- According to Hieun Tsang, there were **four divisions of the society namely Brahmins, Kshatriya, Vaishyas, and Shudras**. It continued to be in practice as in the previous times.
- **People were honest and not deceitful in their conduct.**
- The butchers, fishermen, dancers, and sweepers were asked to stay outside the city.
- Even though the caste system was rigid, there was **no social conflict** among the various sections of the society.

Position of Women:

- Hieun Tsang's account provides us with information on the position of women and the marriage system of the times.
- **Women used to wear *purdah*.** Hieun Tsang, however, added that the *purdah* system was not followed among the higher class. Eg. He pointed out that Rajyasri did not wear *purdah* when listening to his discourse.
- **Sati was in practice.** Eg. Yashomati Devi, a wife of Prabhakara Vardhana, immolated herself after the death of her husband.

Lifestyle:

- People lived simple lives.
- **They dressed in colourful cotton and silk clothes.**
- **The art of weaving fine cloth had reached perfection.**
- Both men and women adorned themselves with gold and silver ornaments. The king wore extraordinary ornaments.
- **Garlands and tiaras of precious stones, rings, bracelets, and necklaces** were some of the ornaments used by the royalty.
- The wealthy merchants wore **bracelets**. Women used **cosmetics**.

Dietary Habits:

- Hieun Tsang also noted that Indians were mostly vegetarians.
- The use of onion and garlic in the food preparation was rare.
- **The use of sugar, milk, ghee and rice in the preparation of food or their consumption was common.**
- **On certain occasions, fish and mutton were eaten.**
- Beef and meat of certain animals were forbidden.

Education:

- Education was imparted in the monasteries.
- **Learning was religious.**
- Much religious literature was produced.
- **The Vedas were taught orally and not written down.**
- **Sanskrit was the language of the learned people.**

- An individual took learning between 9 and 30 years of age.
- Many individuals devote their whole life to learning.
- The wandering bhikkhus and sadhus were well known for their wisdom and culture.
- The people also paid respect to such people of moral and intellectual eminence.

Decline and Legacy

End of the Empire and Harsha's Legacy

- Harsha's empire began to decline after his death in 647 CE. Since he had no heirs, his empire disintegrated into smaller regional kingdoms.
- Despite the collapse of his empire, Harsha is remembered as one of the last great rulers of northern India before the Islamic invasions.
- His reign was marked by peace, prosperity, and cultural achievements that left a lasting impact on Indian history.
- Harsha's patronage of the arts and education, especially his support for Nalanda University, has cemented his place as a key figure in India's intellectual history.